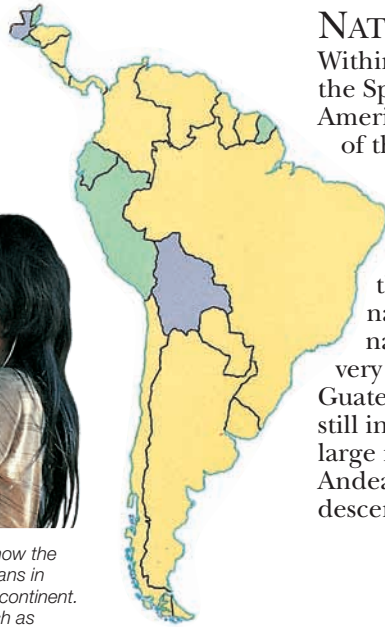


Key

- 50% and more
- 10–49%
- Less than 10%



This map is shaded to show the percentage of native Indians in each country across the continent. Some native Indians, such as this Yaminahua Indian woman and child, in Peru, now live on special reservations.



Refugees from the countryside building a shack on the outskirts of Buenos Aires, Argentina

**CROWDED CITIES**

Nearly three-quarters of the continent's population lives in cities. In some countries, such as Chile and Uruguay, more than a third of the population lives in the capital. Many people have been forced to migrate from rural areas to escape widespread poverty, or have been drawn to the cities by the chance of work. They now live in crowded shantytowns that have grown up on the city outskirts.

POPULATION GROWTH

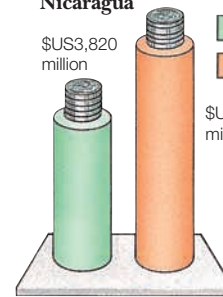
In the 20th century, population growth across the continent was rapid, particularly in Brazil and the northern countries. In most countries, birth rates are now beginning to fall. However, since so much of the population is young, and improvements in health care allow more children to survive into adulthood, the population is still growing. By the end of 2005, another 80 million people were living there.

**NATIVE PEOPLES**

Within a hundred years of the Spanish arrival in South America, as much as 90 percent of the native population had died, mainly from diseases brought by Europeans, such as smallpox and measles, against which the native peoples had no natural immunity. Today, native Indians make up a very small minority, except in Guatemala, where Mayan people still inhabit the highlands in large numbers, and in the Andean ranges of Bolivia, where descendants of the Incas live.

**Nicaragua**

\$US3,820 million



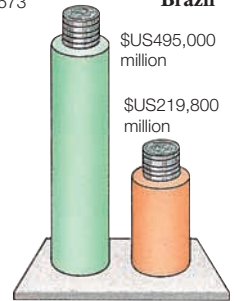
Value of country's goods and services
Country's debt

\$US4,573 million

Brazil

\$US495,000 million

\$US219,800 million

**FOREIGN DEBT**

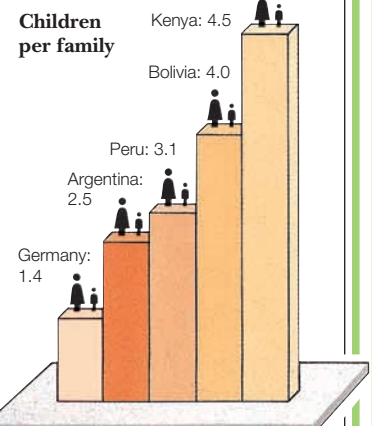
All governments borrow money. The loans are paid back using the money that the country earns by exporting its goods. However, many countries in Central and South America have huge debts. Brazil has a very large foreign debt, but it is still relatively small compared to Brazil's earnings. Nicaragua has a much smaller debt, but the country's earnings are even less.

**LARGE-SCALE FARMS**

Across the region, ranches for cattle and sheep and plantations growing export crops, such as bananas and sugar, often extend over a vast area and are operated as profit-making businesses. These huge farms may be owned by foreign companies or by a handful of rich and powerful families. Cuba is different, for the government controls these large estates.

SMALL-SCALE FARMS

Most of the continent's farmers have only enough land to support one or two people. People like this Bolivian family grow crops and keep a few animals, such as chickens or pigs, to eat rather than to sell. Since the farm often cannot provide enough food for the whole family, some family members are forced to move elsewhere in search of work.

Children per family

This chart shows the average number of children per woman in five countries. Birth rates in Central and South America are lower than in Africa, but higher than birth rates in Europe, where most families have 1 or 2 children.